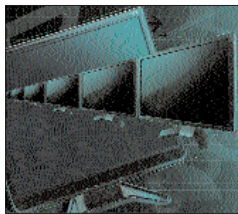




50 Handset Happiness



86 Audio Standards



88 Panel Panorama

Digital Tools

Technology For Personal And SoHo Productivity

Enhance

Disaster-Proof Your PC

One day everything's fine and dandy; the next, poof! Bye-bye data...

Agent001

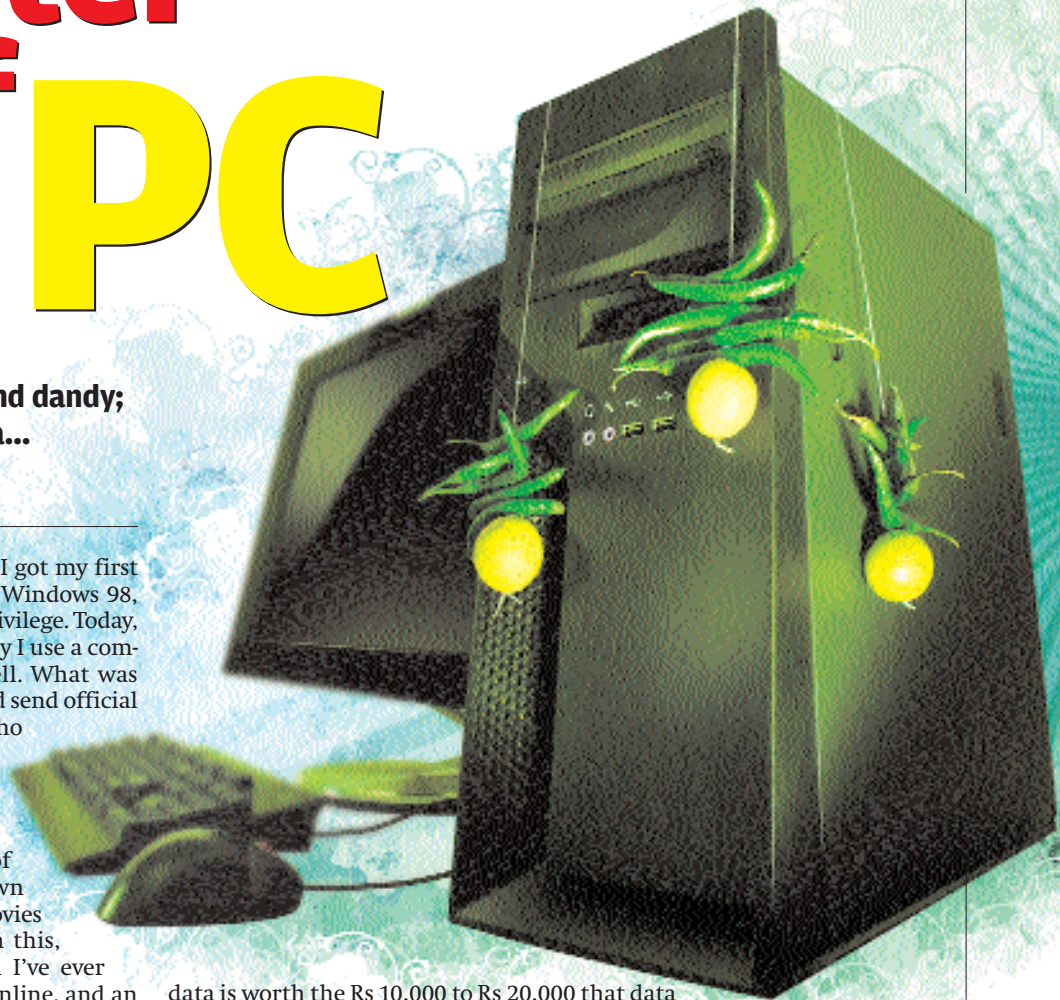
Ten or 12 years ago, when I got my first taste of Windows 95 and Windows 98, using a computer was a privilege. Today, it's almost a right. The way I use a computer has changed as well. What was once a tool to work on Excel files and send official e-mails to the four people I knew who had e-mail addresses is now like a life-support system I cannot live without. I have about 10 GB of e-mail in Outlook, everything I've ever written for *Digit*, over 40 GB of MP3s (no, they're not pirated, I own the CDs), and hundreds of GBs of movies ripped from my DVDs. Apart from this, there's pictures of every vacation I've ever taken, some funny things I found online, and an entire 120 GB hard drive dedicated to software I like—freeware and shareware. The software is, obviously, expendable, and is the first thing I start getting rid of when I need space, but everything else is irreplaceable!

Now this is my home computer. My office computer has a lot less personal data, but a lot of important documents, e-mails, spreadsheets, and such.

Recently, two people in the *Digit* team had hard drives die, and lost a lot of personal data. Of more urgent concern was the fact that they lost work they had just completed, and had to begin from scratch. Now they're busy trying to recover data from their lifeless disks. Whether or not the

data is worth the Rs 10,000 to Rs 20,000 that data recovery experts will charge to "attempt" to recover the disks' contents is something each one of us decides only after facing the dilemma. But why do we?

Just yesterday, I got a call from a damsel in distress. Her laptop just stopped working, and now gives her the weird error message "Operating System not found." It's a branded laptop, and still under warranty, so getting another hard drive and a fresh install of the OS is free. Recovering 10 years of memories, which she had stored on the disk in the form of digital pictures? Rs 15,000, and they'll recover what they can. I can't even help her, because if I open up the laptop to remove the drive, the warranty



Imaging Chaitanya Surpur
Photograph Jiten Gandhi